



THE OARS AND OARSMEN



▲ ROWING BENCH AND OAR

The most experienced oarsman took the inner seat and dictated the timing of the strokes to the other three oarsmen, who pulled on the battens.



▲ THE BINDING OF THE OARS

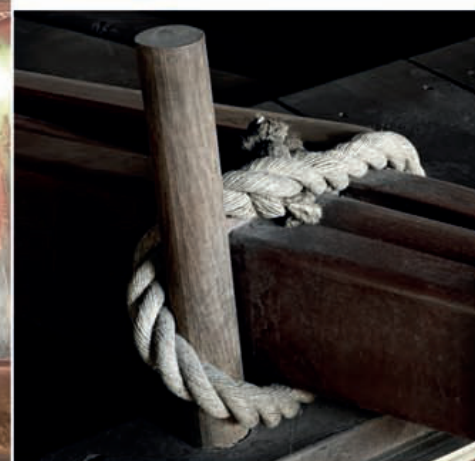
The beechwood oars were 11.2m (37ft) long. Oars made from a single piece of wood were more likely to break, so they were usually made from two lengths bound together.

◀ FRONT VIEW

The forecastle housing the main cannons lay behind the long prow.

▼ THOLE PIN

Each oar pivoted around a peg called a thole pin as the oarsmen drove its blade into the water. The oar was simply tied to the pin with a loop of rope.



► COAT OF ARMS

The *Galera Real* was a gift to Don John from King Philip II of Spain, his half-brother. The prow is decorated with the king's coat of arms, supported by two mermen.



► CLASSICAL FIGUREHEAD

The prow ends in a magnificent figurehead of a gilded Neptune, the Roman god of the sea, who is shown riding on a dolphin and brandishing a trident. The prow of the original ship was removed before Lepanto.

